

Clefs

A clef is normally written at the start—the left-hand end—of every staff on the page. It fixes the pitches of the lines and spaces.

SEE ALSO

◀ 14–15 High and low

◀ 18–19 Notes on the staff

Note values 26–27 ▶

Strings 174–175 ▶

What is a clef?

Clefs are some of the most important signs used to write music. Music notation uses clefs with staves to show what pitch a composer wants in the music. The two most common clefs are the treble and the bass clefs. A third, the C clef, is less common, but is used by particular instruments.



◀ Treble clef

The shape of the treble clef has become symbolic of music in general. It evolved from the letter G, because it marks the position of the note G on the staff.



◀ Bass clef

The bass clef is often seen and used in sheet music. It evolved from the letter F, as its purpose was to mark the position of the note F on the staff.

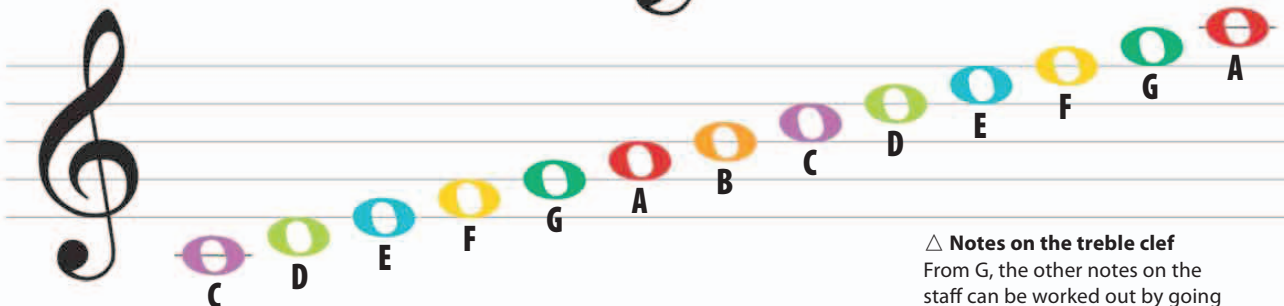
The treble clef

The most common clef is the treble clef, also known as the G clef. The treble clef is widely used by singers and for playing many instruments. It is the usual clef used for writing down a tune.



◀ The G clef

The center of the treble clef encloses the second line up—the G note, curling around it. This fixes that line as the G above Middle C.



△ Notes on the treble clef

From G, the other notes on the staff can be worked out by going forward or backward through the musical alphabet.